AI OPEN
DATA CENTER



Beyond the Build: Autonomous Robotics and the Future of Data Center Operations

Joel Chakkalakal *Director of Business Development, PHS West*

Shashank Gupta- Vice President Customer Engineering, Fleet Data Centers

Evan Johnston- Director of Hardware Engineering, Microsoft

Maureen Tate- Senior Solution Architect, Data Center Infra & DSX, NVIDIA

Rob Lawson-Shank- *Co-Founder & CEO, Molg*

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OCP INNOVATION VILLAGE

Panel Discussion

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Joel Chakkalakal

Director of Business Development
PHS West - Moderator



Shashank Gupta

Vice President
Customer Engineering
Fleet Data Centers- Panelist



Evan Johnson

Director of Hardware Engineering
Microsoft- Panelist



Maureen Tate

Senior Solution Architect , Data Center Infra & DSX
NVIDIA-Panelist



Rob Lawson-Shanks

CEO and Co-Founder
MOLG- Panelist

Panel Discussion

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Joel Chakkalakal

Director of Business Development
PHS West

As a Lean Six Sigma Master Black Belt, Joel applies process improvement principles to build automation-first solutions for clients — reducing hazardous material risks, eliminating inefficiency, and giving personnel back the bandwidth to focus on mission-critical activities instead of manual, high-risk processes.

With over a dozen years of experience across hyperscalers like AWS and Meta, and global brands including Coca-Cola and Formula 1 Racing, Joel has built his career in the white space of data center operations, with an emphasis on dangerous/sensitive goods handling and high-risk movement operations. He has led cross-functional teams and spearheaded initiatives to overhaul dangerous goods transportation systems, delivering hundreds of process optimization projects and saving his clients over $1.8B.

PHS WEST

OCP GLOBAL SUMMIT | 2026

Panel Discussion



Shashank Gupta

Vice President
Customer Engineering
Fleet Data Centers

Shashank Gupta is vice president of data center engineering at Fleet Data Centers where he leads work across capacity planning, data center engineering, development and customer delivery. Before joining Fleet, he spent eight years at Microsoft in leadership roles spanning cloud operations, data center supply planning, integration and platforms engineering and data center specifications, automation, strategy, telemetry and AI modeling. He brings an operator's perspective to the practical challenges of scaling modern data center infrastructure, including how automation can improve safety, reliability, efficiency and speed across the facility lifecycle.

Shashank works at the intersection of business strategy and technical execution, helping teams translate emerging technologies into repeatable operating models and measurable outcomes. He is particularly interested in advancing automation through closer collaboration among operators, technology providers and industry standard organizations

Panel Discussion



Evan Johnson

Director of Hardware Engineering
Microsoft

Evan Johnson is Director of Automation at Microsoft, where he leads a team focused on industrial automation, robotics, and automated systems for data center operations. Throughout his career in aerospace manufacturing, e-commerce, autonomous vehicles, and data centers, Evan has worked at the confluence of technology and operations, leading teams that turn emerging capabilities into practical, scalable solutions for complex, mission-critical environments. His work focuses on the practical challenges of moving robotics and automation from promising demonstrations to reliable systems that can become a fundamental part of how data centers operate.

Microsoft

OCP GLOBAL SUMMIT | 2026

Panel Discussion



Maureen Tate

Senior Solution Architect , Data Center Infra & DSX
NVIDIA

Maureen Tate is a **Senior Solutions Architect for Data Centers at NVIDIA**, with over a decade of experience designing infrastructure for the world's most demanding compute environments. She works directly with customers across the full lifecycle of AI Factory development — from early planning and design through construction and deployment — helping them navigate the complexity of next-generation GPU clusters at scale. Having delivered over a gigawatt of capacity for hyperscalers supporting AI and high-performance computing workloads, Maureen brings a practitioner's perspective on aligning silicon, power, cooling, and construction into a cohesive, high-density deployment strategy

Panel Discussion

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Rob Lawson-Shanks

CEO and Co-Founder
MOLG

molg

Rob Lawson-Shanks is the CEO and co-founder of Molg, a robotics company building the infrastructure for circular manufacturing. Molg's systems operate in factories, live data centers and decommissioning facilities working across the compute-hardware lifecycle from assembly and service to disassembly and material recovery.

Born in the UK, Rob grew up in northern Viriginia's "Data Center Alley," spending much of his childhood around the data halls that power the internet. He later co-founded a consumer electronics company, scaling design and manufacturing in China where he saw firsthand the other end of the hardware lifecycle; his own contribution to a global e-waste stream now exceeding 60 million tons each year. Rob founded Molg to attack that problem at its source: redesigning how hardware is built, serviced and recovered with automation and circularity engineered in from the start.

A recipient of multiple CES Innovation awards, Rob believes circularity is as much a supply chain resilience strategy as an environmental one: some of the most accessible sources of critical components and materials aren't underground, they are already sitting in racks.

Call to Action

- Problem to solve
  - Full automation is no longer a luxury — it's a necessity. The industry already faces a technician shortage projected to reach ~500K by 2030, and manual handling of 7,500+ lb racks and oversized OCP ORW servers puts technicians at risk.
- How to get involved in the project/sub-project community
  - Join the OCP DCF DC Automation sub-project — vendors, OEMs, and operators collaborating on material movement, monitoring, and manipulation & repair automation.
- Timeline for contribution availability
  - Active now — charter and founding whitepaper published 2023; OEM/vendor input is being solicited today to build the technology roadmap.
- Timeline for product/facility availability
  - Near-term: reference designs for automated rack/server movement, plus on-campus micro repair factories for fully automated server repair.
- Link to contribution DB/OCP Marketplace
  - Marketplace listings for automation solutions are in development per the DCF roadmap — check the project wiki for updates.
- Where to find additional information (URL links)
  - Project Wiki: opencompute.org/w/index.php?title=DCF-DC_Automation
  - DC Automation Charter & Whitepaper, Rev 1.0

Open Discussion



Scan to get in touch with the panelists and the moderator

Thank You!

